

Bolivia

 The highest and most isolated nation in South America, Bolivia is named after Simón Bolívar, who, in the 1800s, led wars of independence against the Spaniards. Despite rich natural resources, exporting is difficult because of Bolivia's position. About half the people are Native Americans; the rest are Spanish or of mixed blood.



La Paz

Although Sucre is Bolivia's official capital, the country is governed from La Paz, which also has capital status. At 3,631 m (11,913 ft) above sea-level, La Paz is the world's highest capital and Bolivia's largest city, with a population of about 2,515,000, of whom over half are Native Americans. La Paz has chemical and textile industries, but unemployment is generally high.



Chuqui

Pipes are made from a local reed. The longer the reed, the deeper the sound.

Music

Bolivian music has Incan, Amazonian, Spanish, and African influences. Rural Aymara orchestras are often composed entirely of panpipes, called *chuqui*. Other instruments include drums, flutes, and the *phututu*, made from a cow's horn.



Deforestation

Tropical rainforests in Bolivia are being cut down at the rate of 2,000 sq km (772 sq miles) a year, mostly for cattle ranching or growing coca for cocaine. Chemicals used in the manufacture of cocaine are discharged directly into the rivers of Amazonia, many of which have high pollution levels that damage plant and tree life.



Tin

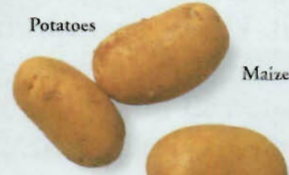
Metal mining

Bolivia is rich in mineral deposits. Its tin mines lie high in the Andes mountains and it is the world's largest producer of tin. It is also a leading exporter of antimony and silver. Other mineral deposits include zinc, gold, and lead.

BOLIVIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITIES	La Paz, Sucre
AREA	1,098,580 sq km (414,162 sq miles)
POPULATION	8,300,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, Quechua, Aymara
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Boliviano

Potatoes



Maize



Barley

Crops

Bolivian farmers living on the Altiplano grow potatoes, soya beans, barley, and wheat for themselves and their families. Rice, maize, bananas, and plantains are grown in the lowlands. Cash crops include sugar-cane, cocoa beans, and coffee, although the profits from illegal coca crops greatly exceed all legal farming produce combined.

Paraguay



The Paraguay River, from which the country takes its name, divides the land in two. To the east lie the fertile hills and plains that are home to 90 per cent of the people. The vast majority are *mestizos*, people of mixed European and Native American ancestry; the rest are Guaraní or Europeans. To the northwest is the Gran Chaco, large areas of which Paraguay won from

Bolivia in the 1930s. Only five per cent of the people live in the Chaco, including 10,000 Mennonites, farmers of German descent who retain their culture.



Beef

The main industry in Paraguay's Gran Chaco is cattle ranching. Herds of animals roam the flat grasslands, tended by skilled Paraguayan cowboys called *gauchos* who round the cattle up on horseback. The farms are called *estancias* and are some of the only buildings in this open landscape.



Macá bag

Macá

The Macá are a small ethnic group who follow a traditional lifestyle in the Gran Chaco. They make a living from farming. Macá women also weave bags and cloth for the tourist trade.



Itaipu Dam

With a reservoir 3,250 sq km (1,255 sq miles) and 220 m (722 ft) deep, the Itaipu Dam, on the Paraná River was undertaken as a joint project with Brazil. It provides water for the world's largest hydroelectric plant and generates enough electricity to make Paraguay self-sufficient in energy.

Dam generates 13,320 megawatts of electricity - enough to supply New York City.



PARAGUAY FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Asunción
AREA	406,750 sq km (157,046 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, Guaraní
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Guaraní



Jesuits

In 1588, Spanish missionaries from the Jesuit order of the Roman Catholic Church arrived in Asunción. They converted the local Guaraní people to Christianity, and taught them trades such as weaving. The Jesuits built large stone churches.

Exports

Soya-bean flour and cotton make up around 50 per cent of Paraguay's exports. The country also sells timber from its forests, vegetable oils, and processed meat. Leading trading partners include Brazil, Argentina, and the Netherlands.

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